

Colossus Cracker

Colossus, the famed British World War II era code cracker, has been beaten at its game by... a German. The machine, built from broken Colossus machines, was pitted against modern machines. It lost to Joachim Schuth from Bonn, whose Ada program broke the given code on his 1.4 GHz PC.



Freebies

EA Inc. has donated the original version of *SimCity* to the OLPC (One Laptop per Child) Foundation. This low-cost laptop is intended for sale for educational purposes in developing countries like Uruguay, Peru, India, Ethiopia and Cambodia.



newsbytes



Marcus Schioler
Product Marketing Manager, Media and Entertainment Division, Autodesk

Autodesk, the creators of Maya and 3D Studio Max, recently launched, in India, the 2008 versions of their visual effects software: Inferno, Flint, Smoke, Flame, Fire, and Lustre. We asked Marcus Schioler—product marketing manager for the Media and Entertainment Division of Autodesk—some questions over a cuppa.

You recently open-sourced a geography software that allows users to convert latitude values between geocentric and geodetic; are you committed to developing open source software?

Supporting open standards is what Autodesk is all about. Though this is not being open source in the truest sense, we provide our customers with custom open APIs that we've developed to better integrate our products with their existing workflows.

For how long do you plan to continue the licensed software revenue model for your products?

We plan to continue with the current revenue model, however, everybody needs something customised to their requirements. We have a specific department that deals with such requests.

What do you think about piracy issues here in India?

On the high-end systems side, we don't see any piracy, but for our animation software, we do. In these we incorporate features like activation-by-phone. We are a member of the Business Software Alliance, a worldwide anti-piracy organisation founded by software vendors to educate consumers on the ills of piracy.

Are you planning a software development team in India?

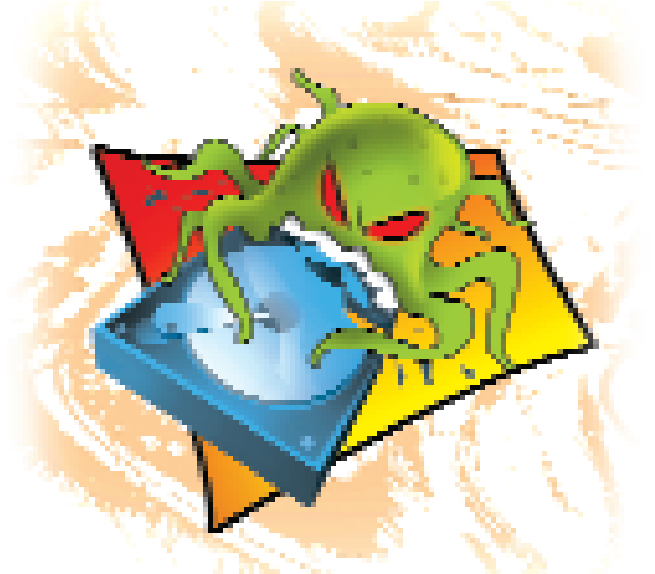
Not at the moment, but there is a lot of feedback that goes out from Indian customers to the development teams working on new versions of our software.

LOADED

Cans Of Worms

What do you do after getting yourself a spanking new hard drive? Unwrap the package, install the operating system, and put your data

sites hosted on a Beijing-based server. Since most of these drives were to be sold in Taiwan, local authorities there suspect a Chinese hand in what happens. (In case you didn't know,



on it? Well, if the Taiwan government is right, the first thing you need to do is to run an anti-virus scan. Especially if you bought a 400 GB Maxtor hard drive from Seagate made in Thailand...

The incident was reported by the Investigation Bureau, a Taiwan government agency. According to their investigations, about 1,800 hard drives shipped from a Seagate factory in Thailand came pre-installed with Trojans. These were programmed to report the contents of the hard drive to a pair of Chinese Web

China considers Taiwan a breakaway province, and relations between the two are not quite rosy.)

All drives from the offending batch have been pulled off store shelves, but those sold before the security warning was sounded are suspected to have had their data siphoned off. Seagate, however, claims the Trojans are not as sinister as they were made out to be: they were merely programmed to steal passwords for online games like *World of Warcraft*, so customers could expect to be blocked out of their

accounts or see their characters lose all those weapons. As a bonus for the customers who were stuck with dangerous software, Seagate has offered a 60-day trial of anti-virus software from Kaspersky Labs to scrub the infected drives clean.

As a post-script: the Chinese have had, for some time now, an unsavoury reputation when it comes to meddling in other countries' IT affairs. Might they have a fully-staffed dirty-tricks department dedicated to cyber-attacks? Not long ago, the newswires were buzzing with reports of China hacking into US military networks...

As for us, we're going to be a little edgy about buying Maxtors from Thailand. If we get one as a gift, we'll look the horse in the mouth.

ANOTHER DISGRUNTLED GOVERNMENT AGENCY

OpenSchool.org?

A generation of young Brits could grow up without depending on Microsoft Office and the effects of Vista's Aero, if the UK government's nodal agency for computers, Becta, has its way. The watchdog group says Microsoft's terms of use for Windows are restrictive and do not encourage competition.

According to Becta, public money has not been optimally spent on Microsoft's systems. The licensing procedure for Windows systems is cumbersome, and schools have to continue paying subscription dues to Microsoft for quite a long time—and if they don't, Microsoft could pull the



plug. Now also take into account the fact that a typical mid-sized school's software budget equals a new teacher's salary.

Microsoft, when drafting the licenses for the schools, apparently inserted some caveats that enable the company to ensure that schools use only its software and nothing else. Schools have to pay based on the number of computers they own, regardless of whether the software is installed or not. The company provides the best deals to schools with more than 250 computers and who could predict demand for the next three years. (Strange, considering Microsoft can't seem to properly plan the release dates of its new offerings.) Another issue is Vista's and Office 2007's hardware requirements and interoperability issues with older versions. The way out of this mess, according to Becta, would be to adopt open source alternatives like Linux and OpenOffice.org—the young 'uns won't grow up believing that Windows is synonymous with "operating system," while the schools would get to save valuable cash.

But on second thoughts, though, the kids would probably get schizophrenic, with Windows at home...

TFLOP DREAMS

Right Up There

For those who have been whining about the lack of cutting-edge, world-class supercomputers in India, now is the time to bring out the bubbly. In a recently-released list of the top 500 supercomputers, India is in fourth place in a list dominated mostly by the United States and Europe. This particular supercomputer, named Eka (Sanskrit for "one," as you should know) is installed at Computational Research Laboratories in Pune. It runs at a scorching speed of 117.9 teraflops (trillion floating point operations per second). Eka is intended for use in areas like drug design, earthquake and tsunami modelling, and crash simulation.

The system, installed by HP this year, consists of 14,240 of Intel's Xeon 53xx 3 GHz processors, and incorporates Tata's own routing technology with data transfer rates of 20 Gbps. Incidentally, this system is Asia's only entry in the Top Ten list, with the next one (from Japan) placed at 16th spot. The United States continues to have the highest concentration of systems, at 284. In Asia China, Japan, Taiwan and India together contribute 58 machines to the top 500 list.

Computer Research Laboratories is engaged in research and development in areas of High Performance Computing and like chip design, computer architecture, and systems software. It was founded in

July 2006, and is supported and funded by the Tata Group.

UNWITTINGLY MALICIOUS

Sign Of The Times

This Diwali could have left a bad taste in the mouth for regular users of Indiatimes.com, all those sweets notwithstanding.

According to Mary Landesman, a researcher at Web security solutions provider ScanSafe, the Indiatimes.com site is serving up a brew of Trojans, malicious binaries, and deadly scripts and cookies. Most of these threats have never been seen in the wild before, so having an updated anti-virus can't help against the threats. They target little-known Windows vulnerabilities, some of which do not have any patches. You wouldn't even know if you were to be attacked—there are no pop-ups or message boxes asking for permission to install screensavers or cursors. You visit the infected page, and bad things automatically get installed on your system, silently and stealthily.

ScanSafe has not identified exactly what the malicious programs are supposed to do, but they have speculated that the infected system might become part of a file-sharing or communication network: in other words, a botnet.

Indiatimes.com is one of India's most popular Web sites, with hundreds of pages. The only good news is that most of the 434 threats are confined to a few pages. The site was notified of the problem when the offices were closed due to Diwali, and there has been no response to e-mail queries regarding the threat scene right now.

People Who Changed Computing

Layer of Security

Now you wouldn't give out your credit card number, e-mail password, or medical history to any stranger, yet every time you shop online or check your



Taher Elgamal

mail, you type in such details without a second thought—implicitly trusting the little lock icon to keep those details safe. Every page that has that icon guarantees that the data entered there is seen only by the intended recipient; that guarantee is widely possible because of the SSL (Secure Sockets Layer) protocol. Taher Elgamal, during his years as a chief scientist at Netscape (1995–98) polished up and introduced the protocol that is now *de rigueur* for any e-commerce transaction. An alumnus of Cairo University and Stanford, this Egyptian-born American cryptologist has contributed in other ways to making online transactions secure. The Digital Signature Standard, based on the Elgamal signature scheme, is an industry standard for generating signatures that authenticate senders and receivers. Elgamal was one of the early employees at RSA Data Security, and was engaged in developing cryptographic toolkits for encryption. He is also a well-known entrepreneur who has been associated with many Silicon Valley security companies like Securify and Ektasis. He is currently CTO of Tumblewood Communications, which provides security solutions for enterprises and governments.